Meanwhile, having settled the affairs of Surat, Akbar set off towards Agra in April 1573, stopping en route at Ajmer. Harkha Bai was sent to Amer to be present at the mourning ceremony for her brother Bhupat and the child Daniyal was brought back into the royal retinue. Now, as the victorious troops headed towards Sikri, the royal astrologer advised them to wait three days for the auspicious moment to enter the city. The Hindu astrologer who bore the title Jyotik Rai was possibly the priest Nilakantha, a protégé of Raja Todar Mal. Akbar used both Muslim and Hindu astrologers and Nilakantha was a learned scholar who would write a commentary on Islamic astrology called the *Tajikanilakanthi*. While Akbar waited for the planets to align themselves, Shaikh Salim Chishti and all the great noblemen of the court came to congratulate him. Shaikh Mubarak, recently arrived at court, greeted him by saying that Akbar had been accorded glorious victories so that he may become peshwa of the spiritual world, words which resonated deeply with Akbar. Finally, on 3 June 1573, a year after he had left the city, Akbar returned home in triumph.

No sooner had he returned, however, than news reached Akbar that the uneasy truce in Gujarat had collapsed and that the same rebels had mutinied again upon his departure. As before, they were led by Ikhtiyar ul-Mulk who was joined this time by Muhammad Husain Mirza.* The rebels had taken Broach, Cambay, and Surat and had besieged Mirza Aziz Koka himself in Ahmedabad. Akbar was furious at this cavalier and incessant questioning of his authority but there was a further depth to the emotion that would drive what was to become the most blistering campaign of Akbar’s long life. This time it was Aziz Koka, childhood companion of his Kabul years, whose life was in danger. Aziz Koka, who was the only nobleman ever allowed to share the takht on the imperial elephant, and who galloped alongside the Padshah inside the raging qumargha circle. And at the harem in Sikri there was Aziz Koka’s mother, Jiji Anaga, who would have come to Akbar to lay before him her great grief and her worry. ‘His Majesty,’ wrote Jahangir, ‘in consequence of the distracted state of Jiji Anaga, the mother of [Aziz Koka], started for Gujarat with a body of royal troops without delay from the capital of Fathpur.’ Jahangir, who had witnessed these events as the four-year-old Salim, realized that it was clearly the faultless love that Akbar had for his milk mother that now made him act as he did. Indeed, according to Jahangir, who admittedly had a more circumspect view of Aziz given his role in the tussle for succession, Mirza Aziz Koka’s meteoric rise at court